

Changed Bodies: Ovid, Sekien, and the Motif of Transformation

In this essay, I will discuss the similarities and differences between Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (1st century Rome CE), and Sekien's *Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro* (18th century Japan). Literary analysts have underestimated the importance of the recurring motif of transformation in *Metamorphoses* by Ovid. Despite its frequent appearance in various plots, many scholars regard it as a way to merely dramatize the work (Larmour 141); others choose to simply ignore it and focus on other interesting aspects of the tales (Janan 286-95). Their underestimation of the significance of this motif leads to their negligence of the similarity of *Metamorphoses* and *Gazu Hyakki Tsurezure Bukuro* (Literally "The Illustrated Bag of One Hundred Random Demons"), an illustrated collection of ordinary artifacts transformed into conscious beings, by Toriyama Sekien.

According to scholar Rădulescu, Ovid was persecuted by Emperor Augustus, who was offended by his work *The Art of Love*, which the emperor thought of as gossip criticizing his family. Composed during his exile, Ovid's *Metamorphoses* suggests that being disguised (temporarily transformed) or permanently transformed is the only way to avoid persecution from a powerful agent. For example, Daphne transforms into a laurel to avoid Apollo (Ovid 20). Likewise, Ovid, in order to avoid further persecution by the emperor, had to have his work critical of the emperor's family transformed into a version disguised in the form of multiple tales involving transformation so that it would seem to be less offensive. In other words, *Metamorphoses* is a book of Ovid's suffering of his persecution. His agents are transformed from persons into objects that are unable to speak, indicating that the poet himself had to keep his mouth shut to avoid the rage of the emperor.

The first type of transformation taking place in *Metamorphose* is physical transformation. Agents undergoing physical transformation are usually the persecuted, and their misfortune enables their transformation. Sometimes, their misfortune results from the fact that the persecuting figures are too powerful. Although transformed, they cannot escape from a tragic end. In other cases, their transformation is caused by their misfortune. For example, Juno changes Callisto's body into a bear instead of killing her; Callisto avoids a more severe persecution from Juno due to her transformation. However, mistaken as a dangerous bear by her own son, she is killed due to her transformation. Scholar Larmour argues that *Metamorphoses* was significantly influenced by Greek Tragedy. Nietzsche draws many examples from Greek Tragedy and concludes that the greatness of humans can only be reflected via misfortunes and adversity. The tragedies in *Metamorphoses*, composed during the exile of the poet himself, suggest a similar idea. In other words, as a reflection of the banishment of the poet himself, *Metamorphoses* indicates Ovid's own mentality of the inevitability of the persecution by powerful figures of the powerless, and the greatness and significance of the powerless will be reflected only via inevitable misfortunes.

The second type of transformation is mental, and agents undergoing mental transformation are always the perpetrators who initiate the persecution of those undergoing physical transformation. The perpetrators are often indifferent towards love at the beginning, but they become set afire when falling in love with others who don't return their love. As a result, the previous indifferent figures become perpetrators who force their love upon those with whom they fall in love. To refuse the unwanted love, the victims will physically transform so that they will forever be beyond the reach of the perpetrators. However, the reason why the perpetrators love the victims is solely because they see the desirable traits of their victims. If the victims accepted

their love, they could enjoy their victims to satisfy their need. In other words, the reason of their love is about them, not their desired lover. Ovid compares the relationship between poets and poetry to the relationship between a perpetrator and the victim: via poetry, the poets explore themselves and therefore connect the subject and the metaphor (enabling the subject to transform into the metaphor).

While *Metamorphoses* is a compiled and textualized response to the decree that banished Ovid to Tomis, a land adjacent to the uncivilized world, *Bukuro* is a compiled and textualized response to people's fascination towards strangeness resulting from an influential political decree that encouraged them to experience nature, an unexplored field where strange experiences, or experiences that never occurred to people, awaited them. *Bukuro* is an illustrated collection of ordinary artifacts transformed into conscious and humanoid beings, by Toriyama Sekien, a Japanese painter in the 18th Century, when the powerful warlord Yoshimune decided that his country should no longer rely on natural scientific studies from "China, Korea, and Holland" and should "develop native industry ... to help alleviate the country's economic woes" (Foster 50). He encouraged scholars of natural science to travel across Japan and study natural objects, so that "domestic pharmaceutical production" would flourish. The country had conferences held for those travelling scholars to discuss their observations and theories of natural science according to the objects they collected, but the goal of the conferences soon changed, having developed into meetings for enthusiasts to display the objects, instead of discussing natural science. Meanwhile, an obsession with "rare and strange" objects grew, and people began to search for ordinary objects with strange shapes to display in the conferences. Later on, such obsession completely dominated the conferences, and turned them into exhibitions where participants displayed both natural and artificial objects, as long as they had irregular and bizarre shapes (Foster 49-55).

Participants would record the displayed objects and publish textual collections of the most bizarre and therefore intriguing objects in a particular conference.

People's fascination towards the strange objects resulted in the creation of many *yōkai* (monsters) in folklores, fruit of people's journey to find the reason why those bizarrely shaped objects did not have the usual forms. People reasoned that these objects must be monsters that were once commonplace objects but underwent transformation under the influences of supernatural forces. Seiken's *Bukuro* is a collection of such monsters that were once ordinary artifacts. These artifacts are transformed, for different reasons. Some of them change shapes because they have reached the year of one-hundred (objects are said to obtain supernatural powers after they reach the year of one-hundred); others are transformed because their owners are legendary heroes or even deities and they are the tokens of the exploits of their owners.

Finished in an era when the fascination towards strangeness was so influential, *Bukuro* reflects such obsession directly. Monsters appearing in *Bukuro* represent such fascination "located on the boundaries between the everyday and the impossible" (Foster 52): They are everyday artifacts, but they are strange in two ways. First, they have strange (humanoid) shapes. Second, they become conscious after their transformation. Seiken, in *Bukuro*, insinuates that some of the monsters were the production of his own imagination, reflecting a dominant characteristic of *yōkai* created during this period: People spoke of their tales based on their wonders and imagination, and those words reinforced the "existence" of the transformed monsters (53). Some objects were not strange, not by their irregular shapes but by the stories of their strangeness that surround them. In other words, their strangeness was a mere result of people's fascination towards their strangeness based on their strangeness, a wonder created by people's words. In short, the monsters are, created by humans, artifacts, but they are different

from other artifacts. Their consciousness and supernatural abilities to change their shapes teased those who had an obsession with strangeness, and the strangeness is but the trick played by people's own mind.

Another notable point in *Bukuro* is that the artifacts, after shifting their figures, become humanoid. For example, *Koto-furuhushi* (the Lord of Kotoes) is a musical instrument with the eyes, mouth, and beard of a person. However, despite its humanoid traits, its body is still a koto, so one can still easily discern its original form. Similar to many *yōkai* in *Bukuro*, *Koto-furuhushi* appears to be the fusion of both human and artifact, representing the disappearance of the boundary between humans and objects. If “seeing,” or perception, was believed to be shaped by people's words in Japan of the eighteenth century (Foster 53), the perceptions, including people's perception of themselves, were believed to be shaped by humans. In other words, all perceptions are artifacts. Since the device they use to perceive themselves is artificial, the boundary between natural identity as humans and identity given by the artificial perceptions is blurred. As a result, the boundary between artifacts and humans no longer exists, because the perception that informs people of an artifact being artificial and the perception that informs people of a person being non-artificial are both artificial. Determined by the same artificial device, both humans and artifacts were perceived to be artificial. Therefore, representing *yōkai* created in the eighteenth century, monsters in *Bukuro* indicates the disappearance of boundary between humans and artifacts.

Ovid and Sekien use the motif of transformation differently. I claim that monsters in *Bukuro* represent the disappearance of boundary: between humans and artifacts. I also claim that Ovid's *Metamorphoses* is an innuendo to his own exile.

1. Ovid and the Persecuted Agents

In Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the agents that undergo transformation are always persecuted by means of love or sexual desire. In some cases, the transformation is physical: Daphne pleads with her father, the river god Peneus, to destroy her beautiful body that "has given too much delight" (Ovid 19) and transform her into a tree so that Apollo will stop being interested in her. Narcissus, agonized by falling in love with his reflection, dies from his tortuous passion and transforms into a flower (68-73). In other cases, the transformation is mental; the subjects, previously indifferent, become inflamed in love and abandon their aloofness. For example, Apollo used to be completely absorbed in fighting and killing enemies; he even bragged of his exploit of killing Python to Cupid (17). However, after he falls in love with Daphne, he chases the fleeing nymph with passion.



Apollo and Daphne by Bernini¹



Narcissus by Caravaggio²

¹ Picture source: <http://www.columbia.edu/cu/arhistory/faculty/Cole/Bernini-Struts.pdf>

² Picture source: http://www.everypainterpaintshimself.com/article/caravaggios_narcissus

Physical Transformations

Physical transformations require the subjects to give up their previous bodily existence and take the forms that are more indicative of their essence than their previous shapes. For example, in the story of *Apollo and Daphne*, Daphne is transformed into a plant whose physical coldness is a better indicator of her essence, which is her aloofness, than her human form. The tragic story begins when Cupid shoots Apollo with the arrow that ignites love and Daphne with the arrow that extinguishes love. After falling in love with the maiden who will never return his affection, Apollo chases Daphne who desperately flees from him. The duality of forcing his love upon her and refusing the unwanted love ends when Peneus, Daphne's father, transforms her body into a laurel. Her feet are implanted into the ground, so Apollo catches her and declares the victory of making her his: "Since you can never be my bride, my tree at least you shall be!" What Apollo loves is her aloofness: the nymph pledges herself to the virgin goddess Diana and takes delight in hunting in the unexplored wilderness. As a result, after her beauty has gone, he "[loves] her still," because "her grace" (20), that aforesaid essence, is not only unchanged but also intensified by her new shape in three aspects. First, Daphne was a person of flesh-and-blood, but now she has become a plant without body temperature. The physical coldness of her new form corresponds to her aloofness when she was a person. Second, Daphne loses her ability to speak and express her will after her transformation: after he offers her the glory of being the symbol of his immortality and honor, she shakes her branches and "[seems] to consent" (20). She becomes less communicative and, thus, more distant and aloof. Third, by transforming into a tree, she is indeed beyond the reach of Apollo and forever intangible to him; even if he catches her, she will never be his wife. In other words, although her body has changed, her aloofness, the essence that keeps her in the intangible and unexplored wilderness whose existence is beyond the

reach of the powerful god, not only persists but also gets emphasized by her newly gained physical coldness.

Likewise, the essences of Narcissus, his aloofness and loyalty, are preserved and amplified by his transformation. Despite his ravishing beauty that infatuates men and women alike (Ovid 68), Narcissus is aloof, cold, and distant, since his arrogance is “so fierce no boy, no girl, could touch him.” After rejecting the love of Echo, he goes to a pond “to which no shepherds come, no goats, no cattle ... no falling leaf [has] even troubled” (Ovid 70). Narcissus is the only animate being around the pond, and he is integrated within the unexplored place, because both he and the place are intangible, out of the reach of others. The sun cannot warm the pond, and the coldness of the water in which he sees the reflection corresponds to the reflection, which is “cold both figuratively and literally,” since the reflection is not a living person and therefore cold (Janan 289). Narcissus is very similar to Daphne, because both are beautiful and intangible, but what separates him from her is the second essence of him, Narcissus’s loyalty to his love. After he falls in love with his reflection whom he mistakes as another person, he suffers from the discovery that he can never touch this person. However, instead of giving up the hopeless love, he gazes at that reflection in painful yearnings and refuses to eat or drink. As a result, he is slowly consumed by his loyalty to the imaginary lover. “As yellow wax dissolves with warmth around it, as the white frost is gone in morning sunshine,” his health is gone, “with the ruddy color going, the strength and hardihood and comeliness.” Then he dies and his family finds no corpse to bury, “only a flower with a yellow center surrounded with white petals” (Ovid 72-72). Ovid uses yellow and white, two unhealthy colors, to describe the fading of his health ruined by his loyalty to his own shadow. Although many who fall in love with him have been rejected and frustrated by him, “none [dies] of [their love towards him]” (Janan 291), even Echo,

whose own body has disappeared because of her sorrow of getting rejected by him, survives. Among the victims of his beauty, Narcissus, the most loyal suitor of himself, dies for his love. Although the body of Narcissus seems to transform into a flower after he dies, the whole scenario in which the flower exists is his actual transformation that indicates his essences better than his human form. First, similar to the tree that Daphne transforms into, the flower as a plant lacks body temperature and thus expresses the first essence, his coldness, better than his previous form, his warm human body, does. Second, the flower “with a yellow center surrounded with white petals” represents the affliction that his loyalty forces upon him, because Ovid uses the same colors to describe his dying body. Also, Narcissus dies by the lake, the same place where he gazes at his reflection loyally. His body transforms into a flower in the same place so that the flower can “see” its reflection in the water. In other words, the transformation of Narcissus consists of both the flower and the water that holds the projection of it. The whole scenario demonstrates his essences, his aloofness and loyalty, better than his previous form.

Daphne and Narcissus transform from persons into animals and trees, as many other agents in *Metamorphoses* do. Daphne’s transformation represents her intangibility better than her human form, and Narcissus’s transformation continues to express his loyal and undying love towards his beloved figure after his human form, having perished, is no longer capable of doing so. In other words, nearly every transformation tale in *Metamorphoses* is a tragedy, but the persecuted agent always manages either to survive or have his or her goal achieved, after the sacrifice of giving up the body of a reasonable being and accepting the form of an unreasonable one, either a plant, an animal, or a statue. Since the forms of the less rational creatures they take are better indicators of their essences than their human forms, Daphne and Narcissus are signs, while the laurel and the daffodil can be taken as metaphors of the signs. Because the tales of

Daphne and Narcissus are very exemplar, for all the agents that undergo transformation, their new forms are metaphors for their previous being. The process of transformation replaces the “gap between [signs] and [referents]” (Janan 287) and makes the subjects and metaphors inseparable. Psychoanalyst Kristeva interprets the enjoyment of confounding “self and other, subject and object, I and you” as “creative impetus” to poets (287). Apollo’s persecuting love enables Daphne’s transformation, while Narcissus’s love towards himself changes his corpse into the flower. In other words, love serves as the “creative impetus,” the bridge that connects subjects and metaphors.

Mental Transformations

In *Metamorphoses*, tales are generally about perpetrators who, consumed by unquenchable love, attempt to rape the persecuted. While the persecuted are transformed physically, the perpetrators in both stories we have discussed, Apollo and the boy whose love persecutes himself, undergo mental transformations. Before inflamed by love, both Apollo and Narcissus despised love. The former is proud in his archery that kills the Python and scorns Cupid for using the same weapon for a “lower” purpose: “to get the love fire burning.” Then, he warns Cupid not to “meddle with honors that are [his].” Since Apollo is known for his archery, his warning indicates that he doesn’t want the weapon that symbolizes him to be contaminated by love, a toy for “silly youngster[s]” (Ovid 16-17). Likewise, Narcissus takes pleasure in hunting and drives away all of his suitors. His repulsion towards love is shown when he declares that he would rather “die before [he] gives [Echo] a chance at [himself]” (Ovid 68-69).

However, love, symbolizing the “creative impetus” that connects the subjects and metaphors, drives them crazy. Apollo is the god of rationality, the “revealer” of truth, and the “lord of Delphi” who gives oracles and guides the mortal; he is the definition of sanity and

reasonability. Yet even Apollo cannot resist the influence of love. Thus, he “is fooled by his own oracles” (Ovid), for he cannot remain rational and reasonable as the giver of instructions and oracles under the influence of love. Similarly, after he falls in love with his own reflection, Narcissus does realize the truth that “he is [himself]” (Ovid 72), but he renounces the truth, as he continues to address the reflection as if *he* is another person. In other words, “the Delphic guide of rational living” (James 17) is overcome by his irrational love.

The mental transformation of Apollo and Narcissus, resulting from love, enables them to initiate the physical transformation of the persecuted. Simply put, the mentally transformed agents are poets visited by inspiration that cannot come from the reasonable consciousness. Under the influence of love, irrational and overwhelming, Apollo and Narcissus initiate the physical transformation of the persecuted; under the influence of such inspiration, the poets connect subjects with metaphors, and poetry is composed. Similar to Nietzsche who argues that “the poet is unable to write until reason and conscious control have deserted him” (81), Ovid, comparing “creative impetus” with love, suggests the same idea.

“Creative impetus” that fills the “gap between [signs] and [referents]” (Janan 287) is the process of self-exploration of the poets, just as love is the process of self-exploration of the persecutors. Narcissus is tantalized by the unreal reflection in the pond. Although the reflection is his, it is not he, for he is a person, an entity, but it is a mere illusion. Narcissus “[falls] in love with that unbodied hope, and [finds] a sustenance in what [is] only a shadow” (Ovid 70). His desire gives the reflection a “sustenance,” which is completely created by him. He imagines that the reflection is a real person living under the surface of the water with all desired traits that he wants. Meanwhile, Daphne is completely intangible to Apollo because she is wounded by the arrow that extinguishes love, and her permanent intangibility draws the interest of Apollo, who

can't stop thinking about the images of her unrevealed body parts, the taste of her lips, and her image of having the beautiful hair combed (18). What he depicts in his mind is not fully revealed to him so that he is granted an imaginary field on which he will find something he can enjoy in her, and such enjoyment, conducted by his own feeling, is what he desires. In other words, Apollo's love results in his imagination of the nymph's body, and under the effect of this imagination he recognizes desired traits that he wants from her. By enjoying her, he will explore his desire, which is about him, not her, because she is the metaphor of his desire.

Just as Apollo sees the possibility to explore his desires and therefore recognize himself via that lovely body covered by clothes, Ovid sees Apollo as an aloof and distant image in which he can explore himself. Apollo was a figure from a *Homeric Hymn* which was composed before the age of Ovid, so the god was distant, intangible, and aloof to Ovid. However, he re-describes the son of Jove as a lovesick figure who yearns for another distant, intangible, and aloof being, because Ovid, a poet whose "vivid imagination" brings him long-lasting fame (Rădulescu 22) and serves as the connection between him and the metaphors, recognizes himself via Apollo, a figure distant to Ovid himself: the god is immortal, as "the revealer of present, past and future" (Ovid 19), while Ovid claims that he will be immortal, too, because his *Metamorphoses* "will endure ... beyond Jove's anger, fire and sword, beyond time's hunger" (392). Comparing Apollo to himself, love to poetry and metaphor, Ovid's obsession in using love as the topic of his various works is explained. Essentially, love and poetry function similarly.

Transformations as Self-Projections

Because love is irrational and beyond the control of both men and god alike, Ovid thinks that it is disastrous. "Creative impetus", comparable to love in *Metamorphoses*, is as devastating

as love, because poetry, the product of “creative impetus,” is beyond the control of the poets, according to the insufficient record of Ovid’s life. During his life time, Ovid lived when Rome was ruled by the Emperor Augustus who strongly discouraged immoral sexual behaviors in Rome. The Emperor initially ignored “decadent behaviors within his own family,” until the “libertine” deeds of his niece Iulia Minor became too notorious to cover. Finally, having not given up on eliminating “public debauchery,” Augustus had to banish her to save his family from being a public joke (Rădulescu 51). Along with Iulia Minor, Ovid was banished as well due to his *Ars amandi* (“The Art of Love”), a book that literally teaches young men how to “choose and seduce a woman” (33). In other words, scholar Rădulescu argues that the direct cause of his exile was a collection of poetry deemed as an obscene publication by the emperor due to its erotic content. His banishment was a result of both his poems and his advocacy of love. Therefore, to Ovid, both were disastrous.

The tales of *Apollo and Daphne* and *Narcissus* are simply disguised versions of *Augustus and Ovid*. First, Daphne is the victim of Apollo’s desire and Narcissus is persecuted by his love towards himself, while Ovid was the victim of the scandals of Iulia Minor, resulting from her desire. They are all victims of love. Second, Daphne has done nothing to incur the desire of Apollo; her tragedy is merely a result of being the victim that Cupid happens to choose; Narcissus, too, does not incur his own love intentionally. Meanwhile, Ovid had neither done anything intentionally to offend the Emperor, nor given birth to a pornography the intent of which was nothing but provoking people’s carnal desire. Third, the only way for Daphne to avoid being forced by Apollo is to transform in to a laurel so that she can abandon the beauty that brings her misfortune. Narcissus also transforms into a flower, so both Daphne and Narcissus are no longer able to speak. Given Ovid’s misfortune, the persecuted agents that

undergo physical transformation also serve as the projection of Ovid himself. Ovid, banished to Tomis, lamented over the loss of his “poetical powers” as well as his fluency in Latin since no one in Tomis could speak Latin and hence appreciate his works (Williams 50). Fourth, having become plants, Daphne and Narcissus can no longer move, and thus become more vulnerable. At the same time, Ovid’s exile was the evidence of his vulnerability when confronting the mighty emperor; he had no choice but to leave his homeland and suffer from the loss of his “poetical powers”. Therefore, the plots in which Daphne and Narcissus are deprived of the power to speak are parallel to the poet’s experience of the deprivation of his “poetical powers” and the fluency in his native tongue.

We have examined the similarity between love and poetry, and Ovid’s banishment from Rome as a result of a book of poems of love. However, given the devastating effect of both love and poetry, Ovid doesn’t renounce his passion for both, which can be interpreted as metaphors to each other, as they can function the same. Instead, he continued composing, thinking that he would be immortalized by his *Metamorphoses*, a work “beyond time’s hunger” and the warfare of men. In *The Epilogue* of his magnificent *Metamorphoses*, he claims that “[his] better part ... will be borne above the stars” and live as long as his works are read (Ovid 392). While his poetry makes him immortal, Apollo’s love for Daphne makes her immortal, because the laurel will be “always youthful as [his] head” and “always ... green and shining.” Meanwhile, although Narcissus has entered the underworld, he never actually dies. His supposedly dead body takes the form of a flower that lives even after his death. In other words, his persistent, loyal love that makes his body perish also makes him immortal. Similar to Daphne and Narcissus who become immortal after their great banes, Ovid, enumerating his gains, views his painful experience from the viewpoint of a remote self, the self in the future when his suffering ends. Scholar Dames

demonstrates that recollection of traumatic experiences is “a form of therapy” and he explains the reason by quoting from Austen’s *Persuasion*: “when pain is over, the remembrance of it often becomes a pleasure” (117). *Metamorphoses*, a book of persecuted people gaining immortality, is a cure to the weary poet at his journey of exile.

2. Sekien and his Many Monsters

Japanese *yōkai* is an inclusive category, consisting of “monster[s], spirit[s] ... low-order deitie[s] ... [and] any unexplainable experience[s] of numinous occurrence[s]” (Foster 2). The *yōkai* in Sekien’s *Bukuro* belong to a special group of *yōkai*, the *tsukumogami* (“gods of tools”) the existence of which is justified by the common idea that artificial objects will come to life after they reach the year of one-hundred (7), changing their appearance and obtaining a more humanoid form. Sekien’s *yōkai* can be categorized into two groups based on the factor that triggers their transformation, and one of the groups manifest the idea that old artifacts will look more humanoid and obtain consciousness. Ungaikyō (“Mirror on a Cloud”), an old mirror in which a ghostly face is seen, will be an epitome to represent *yōkai* in this category.

However, in Sekien’s *Bukuro*, old age is not the only factor that enables their transformation. The second group consists of belongings emblematic of the glorious exploits of their owners that are legendary people or even deities. For example, Princess Suzuhiko (“Princess Bell”), a bell that takes the form of a female dancer that holds a fan, is the bell of Uzume, the goddess whose dance and music lure the Sun Goddess out of her hiding place and thus prevent all living creatures from perishing due to the disappearance of the sun (Hay 44). Uzume is the goddess of dance and music; fans and bells are associated with her performance. Therefore, Princess Suzuhiko symbolizes the deeds of the goddess herself.

Sekien's two categories of *yōkai* suggest ideas that are plausibly similar but subtly different. The *yōkai* that transform due to their ages are indeed the result of people's self-projection, while the *yōkai* that become famous and therefore change shape because of the great deeds of their owners are the result of people's self-exploration. Nonetheless, both groups denote the disappearance of boundary, between the real and fictitious, the secular and sacred. Finally, both groups suggest that merging essentially different beings shall result in the empowerment of all of the involved.



Ungaikyō (“Mirror on a Cloud”)³ Princess Suzuhiko (“Princess Bell”)⁴

Self-Projection, Self-Exploration, and the Disappearance of Boundary

Bukuro was the fourth and last book in Sekien's series of monster illustrations: *Hyakki Yagyō* (“Night Parade of One Hundred Demons”). The first book of the series includes

³ Sekien, p312

⁴ Sekien, p313

illustrations of well-known Japanese monsters, so the author doesn't give annotation, despite writing down alternative names that refer to the same monsters. The amount of annotation increases gradually in the later books. In *Bukuro*, the *yōkai* are heavily annotated, and the annotation is about the origins of behaviors of the monsters. The increment of annotation indicates that in the last book the *yōkai* are no longer well-known enough so that Sekien has to give expositions, suggesting that some of those monsters, non-existent in Japanese folklore, are invented by Sekien. Sekien writes "[this monster] was conjured in a dreamy state" (Sekien 266, 268, 313) on various illustrations. Although the subject that "conjures" the monsters in his/her "dreamy state" is not explicitly addressed, this subject is likely to refer to Sekien himself. Dream, a state in which the subconscious overcomes the conscious, is a world of darkness and unknowingness. If these monsters were not created by Sekien and Sekien had known them in other tales or folklore, he would have obtained the information when dominated by his conscious, instead of subconscious. He wouldn't have "conjured" them in a "dreamy state." Since the information about these monsters was obtained from Sekien's internal self instead of external knowledge, they are his creations. *Yōkai* in both group illustrate his awareness that these *yōkai* are nothing but his unreal imaginations, since the same annotation of him conjuring them "in a dreamy state" appears on myriad illustrations in *Bukuro*.

Ungaikyō is a mirror floating on a black cloud, surrounded by other inanimate, commonplace artifacts such as curtains and a white rail. The mirror itself looks commonplace, too, except for a ghostly face bearing a scary grin shows up in the mirror, sticking out its tongue, and seeming to make eye contact with the viewers of the picture (Sekien 312). The reflection in the mirror is not flesh-and-blood; the face is an unreal and intangible shadow that doesn't have the body temperature of a living and breathing creature. Appearing in a mirror, a cold and

inanimate artifact, the reflection is cold physically and symbolically. The coldness and intangibility of the ghostly face suggests that this monster, cold and unreal, doesn't exist in the real world where humans inhabit. This boundary that separates it and humans is the line drawn between reality and illusion. Sekien's disbelief in the existence of the *yōkai* is also reflected in the way he draws the appalling face. Attempting to indicate the intangibility of the cold reflection, Sekien draws the face in dots instead of solid lines to make it appears vague and evasive. However, he depicts other objects, such as the curtains and banister, in solid lines. Everything in the painting belongs to the real world, except for the *yōkai* of the mirror.

Sekien's annotation of Princess Suzuhiko can be translated as the following sentences: "The past, in which Uzume brought [Amaterasu, the Sun Goddess] out of her hiding place by performing dance and divine music, was nostalgically recalled in a dreamy state"⁵ (Sekien 313). The "past" that Sekien refers to is the most famous tale around many of Amaterasu's story in *Kojiki* (Picken 27): Afraid of her brother who "[destroys] her rice fields ... and ... much of her property," the Sun Goddess retreats into a rock-cave. "Millions of [deities] request [her] to come out," but it is Uzume whose dance and music lure Amaterasu out of her cave (Hay 44). The tale itself, as a myth, is unrealistic and only exists in the imaginary dimension, and Sekien makes it more intangible. When dominated by his subconscious, he enters the mythical, imaginary, and otherworldly scene and witnesses the divine performance of Goddess Uzume which is actually nonexistent; in his dreamy state, Sekien dreams of this mythical tale in an ancient book that tells the creation myth, the generations of gods, and the stories of the first Japanese emperors. Last but not least, Princess Suzuhiko, the *yōkai* of the bell, is not present in *Kojiki*. Instead, she is a byproduct born from Sekien's "[nostalgia for the past]," which makes her unrealistic already. In

⁵ Translated with the help of Prof. Daisuke Miyao.

other words, the *yōkai* of the bell is an unrealistic creature created by Sekien when he envisions an unrealistic event in a dream, an unrealistic dimension. The triple unreality demonstrates that Sekien knows well that this monster is chimerical and fictitious.

Sekien's awareness of their non-existence affirms the idea that the attractiveness of *yōkai* is a result of people's obsession with "ambiguity" (Foster 54): only in an unrealistic, imaginary dimension in which those otherworldly creatures exist, will their craving for "ambiguity" be satisfied. Such obsession, as Foster denotes, is a cultural entertainment that is pursued by people because it "gives pleasure." Quoting James Combs, Foster thinks that *yōkai* of Sekien's illustrations are not associated with "earnest effort towards some serious purpose deemed worthy of the pain involved" (48). However, he never explains why people find those ambiguous and even fearful monsters intriguing. As a result, he underestimates the significance of *yōkai* and labels them as mere toys. The imaginary and unreal dimension in which *yōkai* exist is the counterpart to the real world, and the *yōkai* serve as people's self-projection as well as the manifestation of the result of people's self-exploration.

Ungaikyō, representing the group of *yōkai* that change shapes due to their old ages, is the self-projection of the one in front of it. Sekien's *yōkai* collections, to which *Bukuro* belongs, can be translated as "The Illustrated Night Parade of One Hundred Monsters." "Parade" involves exhibition, and the dark cloud on which the mirror is floating confirms the idea that Ungaikyō, similar to other *yōkai*, likes to reveal its otherworldly appearance at night. Since the category of *yōkai* includes "unexplainable experience or numinous occurrence," Ungaikyō possibly resulted from the strange and horrifying reflection people see in a mirror at night when there are not enough lights. The reflection in the mirror should be the one standing in front of it. In other words, Ungaikyō is the projection of the person, in front of the mirror, astonished by the

otherworldly reflection of himself at night, the otherworld of intangibility, imaginations, and subconscious. As the embodiment of the viewer's unconscious mind, Ungaikyō, although a projection, is unfamiliar and terrifying to the subject on which the projection is based. Sekien's annotation to this ghostly mirror affirms the idea: "[It is] a mirror that reflects the thoughts of those standing in front of it. However, the viewers don't recognize their own thoughts reflected in the mirror, considering the reflection as the monster that possesses this mirror"⁶ (Sekien 312). Sekien's exposition makes one thing clear: perhaps the mirror has some supernatural power to reflect people's thought; Ungaikyō, the appalling reflection, is not the face of any external *yōkai*. Ungaikyō is the subconscious of the viewers who don't actually recognize their own thoughts. In other words, the relationship between Ungaikyō and a viewer is similar to the relationship "between sign and referent" (Janan 287). The referent retains some characteristics of the sign, yet different from the sign and unfamiliar to it. Thus, the thrill gained from "[making] concrete this absence" (Foster 31) characterized by *yōkai* is the pleasure of self-projection and the quest of exploring the unfamiliar aspect of one's subconscious.

The group of *yōkai* that Ungaikyō represents also denotes the disappearance of boundary between the real and the fictitious. Despite denoting his *yōkai* as imaginary and non-existent creatures, Sekien suggests that, if imagination has a strong influence on people's thought and life, the imaginary dimension will be brought into existence by the its impact on the real world, and coexist with the real world. In his illustration of Ungaikyō, the supernatural *yōkai* is drawn in dotted lines so that its face looks vague and intangible enough to demonstrate that it only exists in a world that is as vague and intangible as the being itself. On the contrary, the banister and the curtains are drawn in solid lines, because they are commonplace artifacts and their existence is

⁶ Translated with the help of Prof. Daisuke Miyao.

tangible and “solid.” However, in spite of the distinctive separation of the real world and the imaginary realm, they coexist in the same dimension – the picture on which the ghostly mirror, the banister and curtains are drawn together. Sekien observes the influence that the imaginary realm has on the real world: People’s imagination and interest have made “the category of *yōkai* a national category” in Japan; Sekien’s work, an encyclopedia of those otherworldly monsters, is no longer a collection of artificial fantasies. It “[has] altered the way people understand and visualize the ghosts of their own folklore ... and local belief system” (Foster 74).

Princess Suzuhiko, representing other *yōkai* that are symbolic of their owners’ great deeds, is a result of people’s self-exploration. Sekien states that he “[conjures]” this *yōkai* in his dream of an event in Shinto mythology. Even if this event was real, its real form will be different from Sekien’s dream, because he knows nothing about the distant past. Therefore, he re-creates this event in his dream, a state in which subconscious takes control and reveals unnoticed desires unknown even to the dreamers. The event witnessed by Sekien in his dream is a manifestation of what he wants to see, instead of what the past truly was: he sees the humanoid *yōkai* of Bell holding a fan and seeming to be dancing, while, according to *Kojiki*, the dancer shall be Goddess Uzume. He sees the dancer facing the sky standing on a high stages surrounded by banisters, while, according to *Kojiki*, the dancer should be performing in front of the rock-cave where Amaterasu hides. In other words, by reproducing the tale, Sekien explores what he wants to see. By exploring his desire, he explores himself. This idea applies to all of those fascinated with *yōkai* that have legendary owners: by creating and reproducing the tales around the objects, people re-explore the original stories associated with their owners. A retold tale consists of desired details that the storyteller wants to see; it is a result of self-exploration of the storyteller.

While *yōkai* in the same group with Ungaikyō demonstrate the disappearance of the boundary between the real and the fictions, *yōkai* represented by Princess Suzuhiko illustrate the disappearance of the boundary between the secular and the divine. During her performance to bring Amaterasu out, Uzume actually plays the role of a shaman: “By entering trances, chanting, dancing ... shamans meditate between their people and the often indifferent spiritual power” (Leonard&McClure 188). She not only performs the tasks of a shaman who plays music and dances, but also conveys the will of those represented by her (other gods) to the “indifferent” higher being who doesn’t care about what will happen to the earth if the sun disappears, since Amaterasu is the ruler of Heaven and therefore higher than all of the gods. The relationship among ordinary people, a shaman, and a god is the relationship among other gods, Uzume, and their ruler, Amaterasu. Via dancing, Uzume conveys her people’s will to a higher being. Comparably, a shaman conveys his/her people’s will to a deity via ritual performance. The ability to communicate and convince a higher being indicates that the shaman has temporarily objectified his/her mortal form and become equal to the higher being so that they can communicate. Hence, shamans symbolize the disappearance of the boundary between the secular and the divine. Princess Suzuhiko is the *yōkai* of Uzume’s bell, a musical instrument essential to her performance, so Princess Suzuhiko embodies Uzume’s task as a shaman. Due to the exploit of her owner, she literally embodies the disappearance of such boundary. More generally, just as Princess Suzuhiko represents Uzume’s shamanism, other *yōkai* that transform and become conscious usually represent the great deeds of their owners. For example, *Koto-furunushi* (“Lord of Kotos”) is a token of the tremendous skill of its master, a blind musician. It transforms because only a few people believe in the skill of the blind musician, and *Koto-furunushi* wants to use its supernatural form to impress people so that they will never forget its master.

The Obtaining of Power

Both Ungaikyō and Princess Suzuhiko are humanoid: the former has the face of a human, while the latter takes the form of a young mortal lady. Notably, before their transformation, they were commonplace artifacts. After the transformation, the obtaining of a humanoid shape indicates the acquisition of the rationality and emotion of humans. The shift from inanimate and insensible objects to animate and sensible beings denotes that those artifacts, upon transformation, are empowered. However, since the image of Ungaikyō is the combination of a mirror and a human and that of Princess Suzuhiko is the fusion of bells and a woman (she holds a set of bells), it is questionable to say that they are objects who obtain humanoid forms. Sekien's *yōkai* are *tsukumogami* ("gods of tools"), and those *yōkai* seem to be transformed objects, but they are transformed humans, too, because they, as the results of people's self-projection and self-exploration, are the altered ego of humans. In other words, the subjects could be humans who obtain certain characteristics of the objects by merging themselves with the objects. In this case, the transformed humans are empowered, too. By becoming *yōkai*, they gain supernatural powers as well as immortality, since *yōkai* are creatures in folklores passed down by generations. As long as people remember these *yōkai*, they are immortal.

The *yōkai* surpass both tools and humans, two candidates of the ambiguous subjects. The mystic beings reveal themselves to Sekien when he is "in a dreamy state," and Nietzsche argues that "our innermost being, the common substratum of humanity, experiences dream with deep delight and a sense of real necessity." Thus, dream is associated with Apollo, the "soothsaying god" (21). In spite of being the god of rationality and reasonability, he also rules dream, because things in dreams have shapes and bodies, and he is "the god of light" who reveals those hidden in the darkness (21). His power of luminosity only serves to embody the darkness, "Dionysiac

rapture,” a state in which a person realizes that everything he has seen and known could be illusory (22). However, having one’s established cognizance shattered and being aware of “the apprehension of truth” are a “terror” too overwhelming for mortals, so they have to rely on Apollo’s luminous power that creates shapes and bodies from the vast darkness, the truth (51-52). Then, by quoting Lucretius, Nietzsche suggests that the satyr, among “the marvelous gods and goddesses who first presented themselves to the mind of men” (19) in their dreams, “[is] man’s true prototype,” demonstrative of what a man truly wants to be (52). Just like the satyr that serves as one of the several things cognizable to people via Apollo’s luminous power in the darkness of truth, Sekien’s *yōkai* are the concrete shapes that reveal themselves to the explorer in the darkness of the truth about ego found by people and the painter himself via self-exploration and self-projection. They aspire to be the *yōkai*, half human and half non-human, for the fusion of two rather opposite components grants them the ability to surpass both human and non-human, allows them to preserve their traits of humanity, such as emotion, and gives them immortality that belongs to no human. In other words, in their dream, people explore themselves and strive to know what they truly wish to become. The *yōkai*, among other invisible and agnostic things dwelling in the darkness, are the shapes that reveal themselves in front of the explorers; they are perceivable. They are immortal, powerful, yet humanoid, representing that people wish to be immortal but are reluctant to give up their humanity.

3. Ovid, Sekien, and the Motif of Transformation

Ovid’s *Metamorphoses* uses transformation to tell tragic tales of perpetrators consumed by disastrous love and their victims who have to sacrifice their human shapes to avoid persecution. His tales are about how an individual is deprived of power: Having transformed into

animals, plants, and other insensible objects, the subjects lose their ability to move or to defend themselves, and thus become more vulnerable to external threats. They also lose rationality or sanity that must be present if they want to express their will. The reason for their persecution is love, a metaphor to poetic inspiration, under the influence of which the affected perpetrators, metaphorical to poets, enable the transformation of the persecuted. Under their influence, the victims, subjects or signs in poetry, are “confounded” with their metaphors that are better indicative of their essences than their humanoid forms. Tales in *Metamorphoses* are a disguised version of Ovid’s exile by Emperor Augustus, who was enraged by his poetry. It reflects how Ovid was deprived of his citizenship and “poetical powers” when he came to a barren land where no one else spoke his language.

Sekien’s *Bukuro*, on the other hand, are about how objects obtain powers. By gaining humanoid forms, the objects are no longer vulnerable to external threats, since their new forms allow them to move and to defend themselves. They also gain rationality that distinguishes them from artifacts and other insensible creatures. The reason why Sekien’s agents become empowered during the process of transformation is because his *yōkai* are the result of Sekien’s self-projection and self-exploration. The *yōkai* are the other demonstration of the one who created them in his dream; the *yōkai* are Sekien. By projecting himself into the otherworldly dimension and exploring himself in it, Sekien was empowered. Since the *yōkai* are indeed Sekien, when Sekien was empowered, they are empowered.

In *Metamorphoses*, subjects forsake their human bodies and transform into animals, plants, and objects. In *Bukuro*, transformations are the other way around: objects that are either old enough or used to be under the ownership of legendary people and deities will obtain a rather humanoid form as well as a conscious mind. In both cases, the motif of transformation can be

detected: The transformed body still possesses some characteristics of the shape of the subject's previous existence: the transformations of Daphne and Narcissus, similar to other transformed agents in *Metamorphoses*, inherit the essences of the agents when they were still humans; people can still tell that Ungaikyō was a mirror and Princess Suzuhiko was a bell, because the former is a mirror with the face of a human, and the latter is a lady who holds a set of bells. The transformation must possess some characteristics pertaining to the previous existence of the subject, because they are evidence of the relation between the transformed body and the previous shape.

However, the motif of transformation doesn't specify which is the original form and which is the transformation, given the fact that the motif exists solely based on the mutual resemblance of the original form and the transformed shape. A context must be given if we want to know which form is original and which form is later obtained. If we did not know that Narcissus used to be a human, we would be unable to determine which Narcissus is the original one and which form is the transformed shape. Likewise, not knowing that Princess Suzuhiko was a bell of Uzume, we would not differentiate her original body and her transformed existence.

The ways that Ovid and Sekien used the motif of transformation is the result of their deprivation and obtaining of power. Ovid was banished to Tomis, losing his social status, citizenship, and even his mastery in poetry; he was disempowered. On the contrary, the reason why Sekien's *yōkai* take bizarre shapes is because they represent the projection of his own ego that he did not recognize. Those *yōkai*, displaying themselves in front of Sekien as his projected ego, informed him of knowledge about himself that he did not even know. As a result, after obtaining the new knowledge about himself, Sekien was empowered. Other *yōkai* were the result of his self-exploration. After the journey of self-exploration, Sekien knew more about himself.

Therefore, Sekien was empowered. The disempowerment/empowerment of the authors explains the disempowerment/empowerment of the agents: because Ovid was disempowered, his agents were also disempowered. Because Sekien was empowered, his agents were empowered, too.

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